



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Leman Academy of Excellence: Sierra Vista
School Website: <https://lemanacademy.com/schools/arizona/sierra-vista-k-8/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Leman Academy of Excellence Sierra Vista (AZ 85635) presents itself publicly as a K–8 charter school offering a classical education focused on building knowledge and character. The website emphasizes a tuition-free, community-oriented environment with small class sizes, personalized learning, and “whole-child enrichment” in the arts, athletics, and academics. While the school clearly adopts a classical orientation (the site repeatedly uses the phrase “classical education”), explicit references to theological grounding, liturgical/communal practices, and heavy engagement with Great Books or Socratic pedagogy are not readily evident in the accessible public materials. Taken together, the school currently appears to be SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL: it embodies core classical vocabulary (classical education; character; rigorous curriculum; personalized learning) but lacks explicit articulation of several key elements that the classical rubric treats as foundational (e.g., theology, liturgy, Great Books/Great Conversation, or sustained Socratic pedagogy at the high-school level) in its public-facing materials.

Key observations driving this assessment: - Core classical framing is present: “Leman Academy of Excellence Sierra Vista is a tuition-free public charter school offering a classical education... read deeply, write clearly, think critically, and lead with character.” - Explicit religious/metaphysical foundations are not foregrounded in public content; theology, liturgy, or worship are not cited in the visible materials. This reduces the alignment with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category of a fully classical program. - The curriculum and pedagogy sections visible on the site emphasize reading, critical thinking, and character; however, direct references to the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; trivium/quadrivium), Great Books/Great Conversation, or Socratic seminars are not overtly stated in the public pages we examined. This tempers the curricular/pedagogical alignment toward full classical criteria. - The Parents & Community category is strongest: the school highlights partnerships with families, a close-knit community, and a collaborative faculty–parent dynamic; public materials emphasize parent involvement and partnerships, which aligns with the classical model’s emphasis on parent participation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Notes on needle-movement: Because the overall pattern leans toward classical framing with clear strengths in community and formation of character, but lacks explicit articulation of theology, liturgy, Great Books, and Socratic pedagogy in public materials, the school falls into the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL band rather than fully CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL. The “What would move the needle” section below outlines concrete, audit-ready steps to elevate to CLASSICAL.

- What would move the needle: Explicitly foreground theology or a sacred/moral grounding if appropriate to the school’s mission; publish clear statements about Great Books/Great Conversation, the

trivium/quadrivium, and Socratic pedagogy in the upper grades; document and communicate a defined, restorative scholé-based pedagogy across K–12; strengthen the living-curriculum narrative (portrait of the teacher; teacher as exemplar).

AUTHORITY AND EVIDENCE: This assessment rests on public materials from Leman Academy Sierra Vista describing the school’s classical orientation, its emphasis on character, and its community partnerships, augmented by the classical education lexicon and six-element rubric guidance in the knowledge base. See cited materials for explicit phrases and missing elements: “Leman Academy of Excellence Sierra Vista is a tuition-free public charter school offering a classical education that builds knowledge and character” and related public content. The knowledge-base resources outline the six classical categories and keywords that anchor the scoring rubric.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot (detailed)

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize a classical education and character formation but do not foreground theological grounding, liturgical practices, or explicit transcendent moral realism. The site couches education in terms of reading deeply, writing clearly, thinking critically, and leading with character, without explicit theology or liturgy mentions.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the Six Essential Elements/lexicon set include truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; reverence; wonder. These terms do not appear in the accessible public content for this Sierra Vista campus. No direct hits for theology, liturgy, or worship appear in the visible snippets. Likewise, negative signals (secular humanism, relativism) are not present. Based on available text, Positive keyword hits: 0; Negative keyword hits: 0.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates classical framing (classical education) and character formation, but lacks explicit text about transcendental moral realism, theology, liturgical practice, or communal sacred practices in public content. This aligns with a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than CLASSICAL, given the absence of core religious/metaphysical signaling in the public materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site states the goal as building knowledge and character and leading with integrity; this signals formation of virtue and human flourishing through classical education. The explicit talk of “character” and “lead with character” suggests formation-oriented aims beyond rote information.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive concepts in the rubric include formation, cultivation of virtue, and pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty. The public content uses character formation language (not the exact term “virtue”); the lexicon treats “formation” and “virtue” as core. Since the public text does not directly quote “formation” or “virtue,” hits are limited. Direct matches to “virtue” or “wisdom” are not evident in the visible text; “character” is a related but non-lexicon term. Therefore: Positive hits: 0–1 (through implied formation/virtue notions); Negative hits: 0. The explicit absence of formal phrases like “pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty” in the Casey-lexicon sense is noted.

Why this rating - Formation/character orientation is present, but the explicit canonical classical aims (virtue-focused formation; pursuit of true, good, beautiful; scholé) are not stated with the exact lexicon in public content. This justifies SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school uses language of a classical education (read deeply, write clearly, think critically), and public materials reference curriculum and a “Reading List” and “Curriculum” sections, signaling a structured, content-driven program. However, there is no explicit listing of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or the Quadrivium, nor direct mentions of Great Books or the Great Conversation in the visible content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive canonical keywords include: liberal arts; trivium/quadrivium; grammar/logic/rhetoric; great books; great conversation; history/Western civilization; wonder. The visible Sierra Vista content does not present these terms explicitly (though it alludes to a “classical education” and to reading/writing/critical thinking, plus a “Reading List” and “Curriculum” page). Direct hits for “grammar,” “logic,” “rhetoric,” “Great Books,” or “Great Conversation” appear to be absent in the public excerpts. Positive hits: 0–1; Negative hits corresponding to “project-based learning” or “STEM-first framing” are not present in the visible text.

Why this rating - The public-facing materials signal a classical orientation but do not provide explicit articulation of the full classical curriculum (Gram./Logic/Rhetoric; Great Books; Trivium/Quadrivium; Great Conversation). This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site emphasizes personalized learning and small class sizes, and mentions a partnership with families, suggesting a teacher-centered but student-responsive approach. The explicit pedagogy (Socratic seminars, chanting, memorization, scholé/restful learning, etc.) is not stated in public Sierra Vista content. The presence of “Personalized Learning” aligns with classical aims but without explicit reference to the classical pedagogical methods.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive pedagogy keywords include Socratic seminars; narration; chanting; restfulness; rhetoric training; upper-school seminars; etc. These are not present verbatim in the Sierra Vista public text. Negative indicators such as “project-based learning” or “experiential learning” (if present) are not observed. Therefore, positive hits: 0; negative hits: 0 (based on public excerpts).

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a classical orientation in naming and aims (classical education; reading/writing/critical thinking; personalized learning), but lacks explicit public statements of classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, narrations, or memory work). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site describes “caring teachers,” a small-campus atmosphere, and staff who partner with families to help scholars succeed. It hints at a mentoring culture and the idea that teachers know each student. This aligns with the classical ideal of living models of virtue and a living curriculum, though explicit language about “portrait of a teacher” or “faculty as living curriculum” is not stated in public content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords include “model teachers” or “living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher”; these exact phrases are not present in the Sierra Vista content. However, “caring teachers,” “dedicated support team,” and “partner with parents” convey the spirit of mentorship and collegiality. Direct lexicon hits for the explicit positive faculty keywords are limited. No negative faculty signals (e.g., minimal teacher development, non-classical staffing) appear publicly.

Why this rating - There is clear evidence of a teacher-focused, supportive culture, which is consistent with the classical teacher-as-mentor ideal, but explicit statements about a formal “living curriculum” or a robust classical-faculty profile are not present in the public material. This aligns with SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize partnerships with parents, small-school feel, and a close, supportive community. The phrasing notes that parents “partner with teachers,” and there are explicit resources for families (Plan a Visit, Enrollment, Reading List, and a strong parent-teacher partnership orientation). The existence of a robust Parent Resources section (including Family Handbook, FERPA, Parental Rights Handbook, etc.) demonstrates active parental involvement and support for parent formation and engagement. This aligns well with the classical model’s emphasis on parents as co-educators.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the Five Elements/lexicon in this domain include “partnership with parents,” “co-teachers,” “parent formation,” “reading groups,” “classical book clubs,”

“open campus,” and “parent covenant.” The Sierra Vista site explicitly highlights parent partnerships, family involvement, and a welcoming environment for visits, which match many of the positive indicators. Direct phrases from the site include: “strong partnership with teachers,” “parents choose Sierra Vista for its small-school feel,” and “parents are invited to visits.” These align with the “Parents and Community” positive keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Why this rating - The public materials strongly emphasize parent involvement, parent formation, and open engagement with the school—clear indicators of CLASSICAL alignment in this category. The content directly supports the classical model's expectation of parents as co-teachers and active community participants.

Aggregate Assessment - Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, the school sits in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL band with a notably strong showing in Parents & Community (Element 6). The other categories show partial alignment with classical elements, but lack explicit, public articulation of several core classical features (e.g., explicit theology or liturgy; Great Books/Great Conversation; Socratic pedagogy; a living-faculty profile).

What Would Move the Needle

- Make theological or metaphysical grounding explicit (if aligned with the school's mission): publish a concise statement clarifying any religious or moral framework, theological influences, or liturgical practices, and how these inform curriculum and culture.
- Publicly articulate Great Books/Great Conversation and core triadic grammar-logic-rhetoric (Trivium) and Quadrivium elements, including how they structure K–12 across the curriculum; publish a public curriculum map showing the Great Books list and representative authors, with a transparent sequence from K–8 (and how memory work or chanting may be used in early grades).
- Document and publicize specific pedagogical practices aligned with classical education (e.g., Socratic seminars in upper grades, narration/recitation in lower grades, memory-work, and periodic “scholé” days) and provide examples of student work to illustrate these practices.
- Expand the “living curriculum” narrative by including explicit statements about the teachers as models of virtue and the portrait of a teacher; share teacher-formation programs and professional development rooted in classical pedagogy.
- Enhance explicit Family/Community formation programming: publish book-club style parent formation resources, schedule regular parent gatherings, and provide clear ways for parents to participate as co-teachers beyond volunteering (e.g., formal parent-study groups, liturgical calendars, and family-learning guides).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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